

FAREWELL SREEJESH, THE MAN WHO BROUGHT US SAVES, MEMORIES AND TEARS

Fans who cheered **"Sreejesh, Sreejesh"** for years will miss the tall, masked guardian in goal.

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Put it down to the luck of the Indians. Specifically, the bad luck. Pitted against an aggressive Great Britain in the quarterfinals of the men's hockey competition at the Paris Olympics, the odds were stacked against Harmanpreet Singh's men. This was compounded by the red card shown to their key defender and first rusher, Amit Rohidas, in the 17th minute for raising his stick and hitting the face of William Calnan.

Despite this, God smiled on India, the sides level at one goal apiece at full-time. GB had pressed and probed, smelling blood. However, it failed to break the deadlock; a visibly exhausted but watertight Indian rearguard somehow keeping it at bay.

A thoroughbred surrounded by warriors, the "Great



If the new crop of players imbibes even a part of Sreejesh's steely resolve and never-say-die attitude, Indian hockey will be better for it.

Wall of Indian Hockey," goalkeeper P.R. Sreejesh, had kept his team in the game with a series of fine saves in regulation time before saving Phillip Roper's attempt in the penalty shootout and catapulting his team into the second consecutive semifinals at the quadrennial games.

India and Sreejesh would eventually win a second consecutive bronze medal and with it, the latter's name engraved into the annals of Indian hockey history.

However, when the team next takes the pitch, goalkeeper Sreejesh, who had announced his international retirement before the Paris Olympics, will be notably absent.

After an illustrious two-decade-long career — decorated with two Olympic bronzes, two Champions Trophy silvers, a World League bronze, three Asian Games medals (including two gold medals), and two Commonwealth Games silver medals — it will be difficult for Sreejesh to watch from the sidelines after donning India's colours in 336 matches, including four Olympics and as many World Cups.